

Illustrations by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GOA

MR & MRS GOA

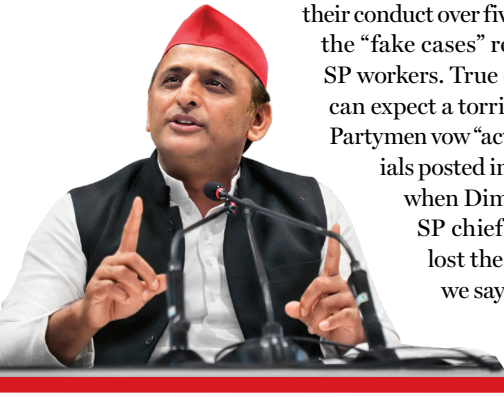
It's almost like those TV game shows where married couples face off against each other for a shiny trophy and a gift hamper. The assembly elections in Goa will see acres of newsprint being devoted to five power couples, no less. State health minister Vishwajeet Rane and doctor wife Divya are all set to contest from Sattari and Poriem respectively. Atanasio 'Babush' Monserrate and wife Jennifer will be the BJP's candidates from Panaji and Taleigao. Michael Lobo and wife Delilah have left the BJP to return to the Congress fold and may be fielded from Calangute and Siolim respectively. Deputy CM Chandrakant Kavlekar, who will enter the arena in Quepem, is trying hard to get a ticket for wife Savitri from Sanguem (last heard, he's quite sanguine about her prospects). These eight seats will play a crucial role in deciding the BJP's fortunes in the 40-member House. But, of course, it's another couple who will be at the helm of the campaign: CM Pramod Sawant and wife Sulakshana. While Sawant contests from Sanquelim, his wife, head of the local BJP women's wing, plans to tour the state to reach out to women voters. **–Kiran D. Tare**

UTTAR PRADESH

Action and Reaction

The Samajwadi Party seems to have a natural liking for Newton's Third Law. But 'reaction' comes later—why not first pre-empt any possibility of 'action'? The party has written to the EC demanding that over a dozen top UP officials be moved out to ensure impartial conduct of polls—on the list are the likes of ADG (law & order) Prashant Kumar, IG Amitabh Yash, additional chief secretary (home) Awanish Awasthi and ACS (information) Navneet Sehgal. The SP calls them "BJP activists", citing their conduct over five years, especially the "fake cases" registered against SP workers. True or not, these men can expect a torrid time if SP wins. Partymen vow "action" against officials posted in Kannauj in 2019 when Dimple Yadav, wife of SP chief **Akhilesh Yadav**, lost the LS poll. Or, shall we say...reaction?

–Prashant Srivastava



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UTTARAKHAND

Rawat Stops Rawat

If the BJP has mollified a sulking **Harak Singh Rawat** (pictured above with CM **Pushkar Singh Dhami**, left) — it has another Rawat to thank. Ex-CM Harish Rawat's retirement threat ensured Harak's planned *ghar wapasi* to his old party, the Congress, was stymied at the last minute. Harak, a Congress CM probable in 2012, has been profoundly miffed within the BJP for a while. Dhami, CM since July 2021, had proved no more helpful than his predecessors on Harak's demand for a medical college in his constituency Kotdwar. And a new no-dynasty rule nixed his daughter-in-law's proposed electoral debut. An angry exit followed...till the revolving doors shooed him back in.

–Anilesh S. Mahajan